

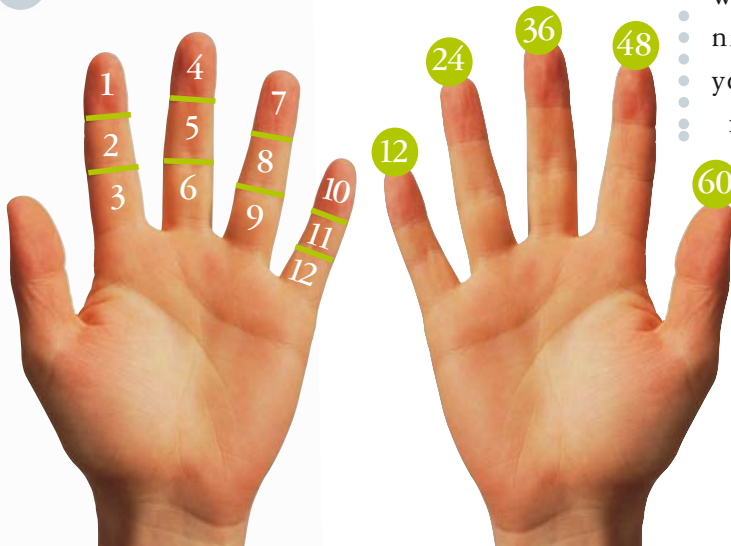


Counting on your hands is fine for numbers up to ten, but what about bigger numbers? Throughout history, people invented lots of different ways of counting past ten, often by using different parts of the body. In some parts of the world, people still count on their bodies today.

IN THE SIXTIES

The Babylonians, who lived in Iraq about 6000 years ago, counted in base 60. They gave their year 360 days, which is 6×60 . We don't know for sure how they used their

one theory is that they used the 12 finger segments on that hand, and fingers on the other hand to count lots of 12, making 60 altogether. Babylonians invented *minutes* and *seconds*, which we still count in sixties today.



MAKING A POINT

Counting on the body is so important to some tribal people that they can't count properly in words alone. The **Baruga** tribe in Papua New Guinea count with 22 body parts but use the same word, *finger*, for the numbers 2, 3, 4, 19, 20, and 21. So to avoid confusion, they have to point at the correct finger whenever they say these numbers.



A HANDY TRICK

Hands are handy for multiplying as well as counting. Use this trick to remember your nine times table. First, hold your hands in front of your face and number the fingers 1 to 10, counting from left. To work out any number times nine, simply fold down that finger. For instance, to work out 7×9 , fold the seventh finger.

Now there are 6 fingers on the left and 3 on the right, so the answer is 63.

